professionalism and conduct left me in awe—and still does. Things were smooth in this term and after about five months, we were sent back to the AFA Dundigal to prepare for our passing-out parade (POP).

We were back to our alma mater in the same squadrons from the first term to spend three weeks there. POP practice was on in full swing. Mornings and afternoons were spent practising and the rest of the time was whiled away in precommissioning paperwork. Exhausted from the morning parade practice, we would hardly be left with any energy to go for it again in the afternoons. The scorching heat of peak summer, mixed with the heat reflected from a metalled parade ground, would leave us drenched in sweat. Every single muscle in my body felt cramped. Though physically torturous and excruciating, POP practice was important. It was supposed to be a meticulous display of our three terms of training. The discipline learnt in training was supposed to be showcased during a synchronized parade. Each arm swing, leg stamp, turning and salute had to be practised a zillion times until it became second nature. There was no room for error. But even as we tanned our skin in the afternoon sun, there was a sense of achievement in each of us. After three terms of back-breaking training, we would finally be commissioned officers. All our hardships, each drop of sweat, seemed worthwhile in the end.

Even after three terms of training, nobody would be told their merit position until a day prior to the POP. Merit positions were based on a cadet's overall performance in flying and academics. These were disclosed during the commandant's dinner-night ceremony the night before.

All of us were very anxious that night. Even though everyone knew how they had performed, there wasn't even the slightest idea about who would make it to the top three. Apart from the top three positions, there were three other titles too: first in overall order of merit, first in flying and first in ground subjects. When the results were announced, it came as an absolute surprise to me when the commandant announced that I had won two titles, including first in overall order of merit and first in flying, apart from being first among the top three cadets. Anuradha was first in ground subjects and second among the top three cadets. Supreet stood at third position. Both of